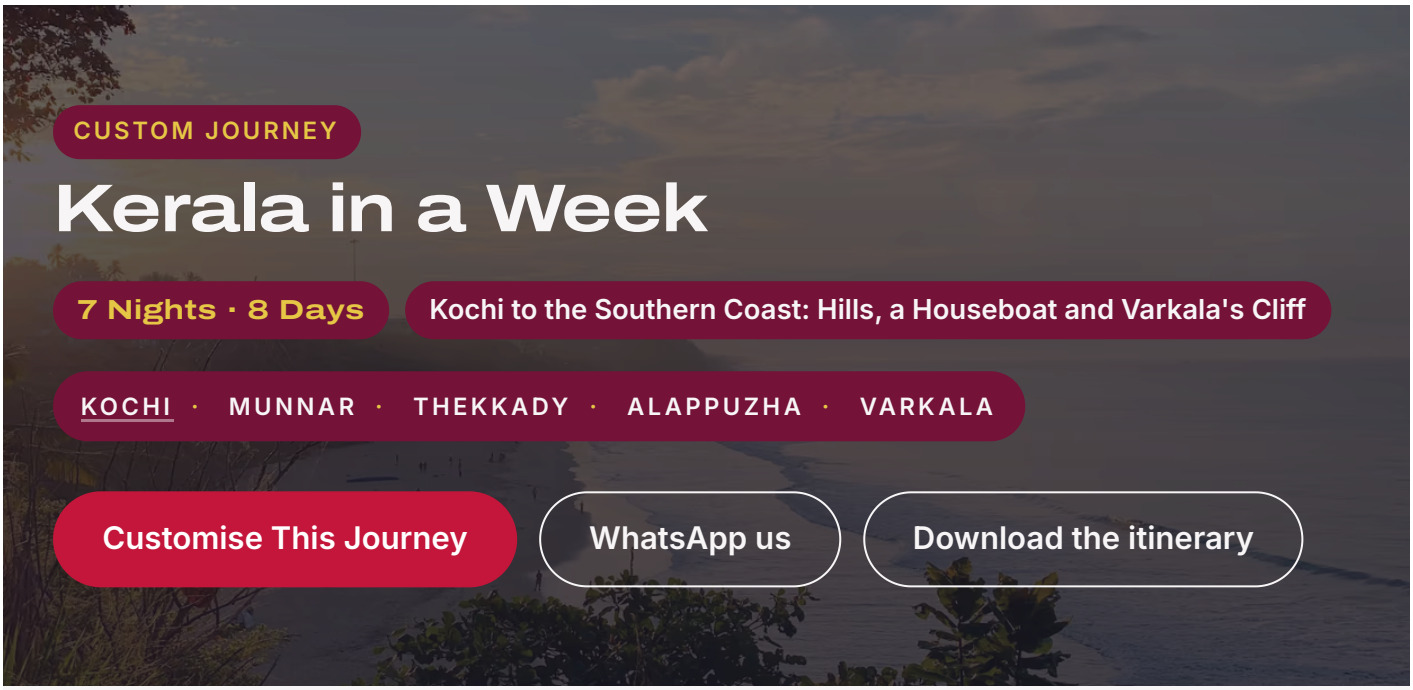
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DURATION
7 Nights · 8 Days

ROUTE
Kochi → Thiruvananthapuram

PACE
Moderate

BEST SEASON
October to March

IDEAL FOR
First-Timers, Couples

Some places you visit; Kerala you sink into. This is the one-week version of that, and it is built on a simple idea: fly into the north and out of the south, so that the journey runs in one direction, from Fort Kochi's old streets through the tea country above Munnar, the spice hills at Thekkady and a night on the backwaters at Alappuzha to a beach at the end, with no long doubling back.

It is the Kerala we recommend to first-time visitors and to anyone with only a week. The longer journeys we run here add a Kodaikanal day and three nights on the Mararikulam sand, or start in the far south and reach Kanyakumari; this one takes the essentials in the right order and stops while you still want more.

Journey Highlights

- **Walk** Fort Kochi at sunset, past the Chinese fishing nets that have worked this shore since the fourteenth century, and the galleries and antique shops of Jew Town.
- **Climb** into the Western Ghats to Munnar, where the coast gives way to tea estates rolling to the horizon and the air turns cool.
- **See** how the leaf becomes the cup at a working tea estate, and look for the Nilgiri tahr at Eravikulam when the park is open.
- **Learn** the cardamom, pepper and clove trade on an evening spice-plantation walk at Thekkady, on the edge of the Periyar Tiger Reserve.
- **Drift** through the backwaters for a night aboard a kettuvallam, with Kerala seafood cooked on board as village life unfolds along the banks.
- **Finish** on the coast at Varkala or Kovalam: a cliff walk, a slow beach day, and an Ayurvedic treatment if you would like one.

Itinerary at a Glance

DAY	DESTINATION	SIGNATURE EXPERIENCE
Day 01	**Kochi**	Arrival; the fishing nets at sunset and Fort Kochi's old streets
Day 02	**Kochi to Munnar**	Up the ghat road into tea country
Day 03	**Munnar**	A working tea estate; Eravikulam National Park
Day 04	**Munnar to Thekkady**	An evening spice-plantation walk

DAY	DESTINATION	SIGNATURE EXPERIENCE
Day 05	**Thekkady to Alappuzha**	A night aboard a houseboat
Day 06	**Alappuzha to Varkala**	Disembark and drive south to the coast
Day 07	**Varkala**	A slow beach day; optional Ayurveda
Day 08	**Departure**	Transfer to Trivandrum airport

Day by Day

Expand all

Day 01 Kochi: The Coast at Its Own Pace

Land in Kochi and ease into Kerala's laid-back coastal rhythm. Fort Kochi's blend of Portuguese, Dutch and British-era streets makes it one of the most walkable old towns in India. Stroll past the Chinese fishing nets at sunset (a Kochi icon since the fourteenth century, worked by teams of men on cantilevered timber frames) and wander the art galleries and antique shops of Fort Kochi and Jew Town.

Explore Kochi →

Overnight in Kochi

Day 02 Munnar: Up into the Ghats

Drive · about 4 hours

Drive up into the Western Ghats as the coastline gives way to rolling tea estates and cool mountain air, stopping at waterfalls and viewpoints along the winding ghat road. The evening is at leisure amid Munnar's tea-garden landscape.

Overnight in Munnar

Day 03 Munnar: Tea to the Horizon

A full day in the hills, framed by manicured tea gardens stretching as far as you can see. Visit a working tea estate and its museum to see how the leaf becomes the cup and, if it is open for the season, Eravikulam National Park, home to the endangered Nilgiri tahr, on the slopes below Anamudi, the highest peak in South India.

Overnight in Munnar

Day 04 Thekkady: The Spice Hills

Drive · 3 to 4 hours

South through the hills to Thekkady, gateway to the Periyar Tiger Reserve, where forested slopes ring a large lake. In the evening, a spice-plantation walk: cardamom, pepper and clove growing where they have been traded from for two thousand years, and a guide who can tell you what each one looks like on the bush.

Overnight in Thekkady

Day 05 Alappuzha: A Night on the Water

Boat · Board a houseboat at Alappuzha

Down to Alappuzha, the starting point for Kerala's most iconic experience. Board a kettuvallam (a converted rice barge with private sleeping quarters, a dining area and a deck) and drift through the backwaters as village life unfolds along the banks, with fresh Kerala seafood cooked on board. Boats moor before dark, and the quiet of the mooring is part of why people remember the night.

Overnight aboard the houseboat

Day 06 Varkala: South to the Coast

Drive · 3 to 4 hours

Disembark after a peaceful morning on the water and drive south for a change of pace by the sea. Check in to a beachside stay at Varkala (or Kovalam, if you prefer a bay to a cliff) and take an evening walk along the clifftop promenade or the beach.

Overnight in Varkala

Day 07 Varkala: A Slow Beach Day

A slow day to close out the trip. An Ayurvedic massage or wellness session is a Kerala speciality and worth trying here; otherwise, the shore, the cliff, and the cafés along it.

Overnight in Varkala

Day 08 Trivandrum: Departure

Drive · 30 to 45 minutes to Trivandrum airport

Transfer to Thiruvananthapuram airport for your onward flight.

Departure

Practical notes

Getting there

Fly into Kochi (COK) and out of Thiruvananthapuram (TRV). Both are well-connected international and domestic airports, and the open-jaw routing is what makes a week enough.

Best time to visit

October to March for pleasant weather. June to September is the monsoon (lush, but wet), and the hills stay damp for weeks after.

The houseboat

Book an air-conditioned boat with an upper deck for the best backwater views. We choose the boat and the crew, not just the stretch of water.

Pace

Moderate. Hills, backwaters and beach are spread evenly across the week, with a private car and driver for the hill-to-coast route.